- **LAWS:** Constitution versus Manusmriti, Eklavya theory to highlight the trials of the marginalised
- **CORPORATE CABALS:** Concentration of wealth, wrongdoings in land transfers, Adanis and alleged crony capitalism
- **ENVIRONMENT:** Great Nicobar project's ecological damage, tribal rights, Forest Rights Act concerns, air pollution
- **FEDERALISM:** Jammu and Kashmir statehood, delimitation and resistance to central domination
- **FOREIGN POLICY:** China and 2020 border crisis, national security, sovereignty and India's dealings with the US
- **ARMED FORCES:** Agniveers and soldiers' rights
- **GOVERNANCE FAILURES:** Manipur violence
- **TECHNOLOGY:** AI and ownership of Indian data

THE INNER CIRCLE



PRIYANKA GANDHI
Rahul can refer to sister Priyanka on any decision, from political appointments to content of a presentation. Suggestions are not always followed



K.C. VENUGOPAL
All decisions related to party affairs delegated to the general secretary (organisation). KC is also the bridge between Rahul and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge



SRIVATSA Y.B.
Former social media head of Karnataka unit vets every communication Rahul puts out. Also, the man behind his spectacular rise on social media



ALANKAR SAWAI
Former ICICI Bank employee is Rahul's Man Friday. Shadows him everywhere, looks after his daily schedule



KAUSHAL VIDYARTHI
Former urban planner and Oxford alumnus takes care of all appointments, travel plans



K.B. BYJU
Former SPG officer takes care of Rahul's security, gathers intelligence for the Congress leader

tion to it. He is now sharper on issues and more effective as a communicator, but his political performance remains inconsistent. He can seize upon an issue, dominate the conversation around it, but then also allow the campaign to meander. His attacks on the Election Commission and *vote chori* illustrate the problem. A forceful political intervention can be followed by a lull away from the domestic political arena.

Political scientist Rahul Verma sees the same gaps. He argues that the Congress scion must engage more deeply with the organisation and the everyday mechanics of electoral politics. "Taking the right positions or generating social media attention is not enough. Voters also look for decisiveness, strong political positioning and constant engagement." Bihar, in 2025, was the clearest example. Rahul's 16-day Voter Adhikar Yatra, centred around the controversial SIR (Special Intensive Revision) of electoral rolls and the *vote chori* allegations, travelled through 25 districts and drew large crowds. But the Congress won just six of the 61 seats it contested.

INCREMENTAL DIVIDENDS

Some Congress leaders argue that this issue-based politics is starting to yield dividends. They cite the Rajasthan urban body polls in September after the party made the alleged "purification" of a venue, after Kharge's Haldwani (Uttarakhand) visit, a social justice issue. The Congress won 542 of the SC-reserved wards against the BJP's 350. State unit chief Govind S. Dotasra attributed the gains to Dalit anger over the episode.

But Rahul faces a much bigger test ahead. Twenty states are due to hold assembly elections by June 2029, covering 2,437 seats. The Congress is currently in power in three of them, Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh and Telangana. In the last assembly elections across these states, the Congress contested 2,252 seats and won only 506, a strike rate of about 22 per cent. Its performance in the coming round of state elections will show whether